

The Reach-Out Ladder (The Whole Thing on One Page)

The complete tool from **Everyone Likes You More Than You Think** by Simon Gebhart.

This page is the book. If you skipped straight here, you can run the entire protocol from this page — evidence tags included, chapters behind you for the details and the caveats.

Rung 1 — the weak-tie rep (*daily*)

One 30-second exchange with a peripheral person already in your orbit — barista, gym regular, dog-park person. Greet, one real question or comment, done.

Tag: diary studies — early evidence; days with more acquaintance interaction associated with more happiness and belonging. Same-day well-being and forecast reps, not friendship.

Rung 2 — the lapsed-tie text (*one per week, minimum*)

Text one person you've drifted from. Scripts:

1. "Was just thinking about that trip to __. How ARE you?"
2. "Saw __ and thought of you immediately."
3. "Been way too long. Coffee next week — Tuesday or Thursday?"

Graded on **sent**, never on reply.

Tag: 13 preregistered experiments — appreciation for reach-outs is underestimated, MOST for socially distant ties; one of the experiments independently replicated at $n = 742$, and held.

Rung 3 — the repeat-hours move (*on any warm response*)

Convert warmth into a recurring leisure slot: day, time, cadence, named activity. "Same time next Tuesday?"

Hours-math box: roughly 50 hours $\approx$ casual friend · roughly 90 more $\approx$ friend · 200-plus $\approx$ close friend — approximate, self-reported estimates. Work hours count less; leisure hours drive closeness. A 2-hour weekly slot crosses the roughly-50-hour line in about six months. "Let's hang out sometime" crosses nothing.

Tag: Hall 2019, Journal of Social and Personal Relationships — hours predicted closeness; leisure hours specifically.

Rung 4 — the initiator's turn (*when Rung 3 holds*)

Own a standing invite — weekly walk, monthly dinner — and hold it open. You send the reminder; you show up even when it's two of you.

Tag: randomized commuter experiments — initiating felt better than forecast, and being approached felt just as good as initiating. The host is not imposing.

Rules, printed where you'll see them

- One Rung 2 text per week, minimum.
- Predicted-vs-actual log, every rep: forecast 1-10 before, actual after.
- No skipping rungs upward — Rung 3 without Rung 2 is why "join a club" failed.
- A silent week costs one text, not the method.

Everything above is an average tendency — most people, most of the time. The ladder never requires it to be true of any one person. Graded on sent.

Do this now: Screenshot this page and pin it in your notes. Then book the first recurring slot that's already lying around: the thing you already do weekly alone — the walk, the gym session, the Sunday coffee — is the cheapest Rung 3 on earth. Invite one person into it.

More printable cards like this, free: [Simon Gebhart's Field Notes](#)

The full guide: amazon.com/dp/BOHL246NQW